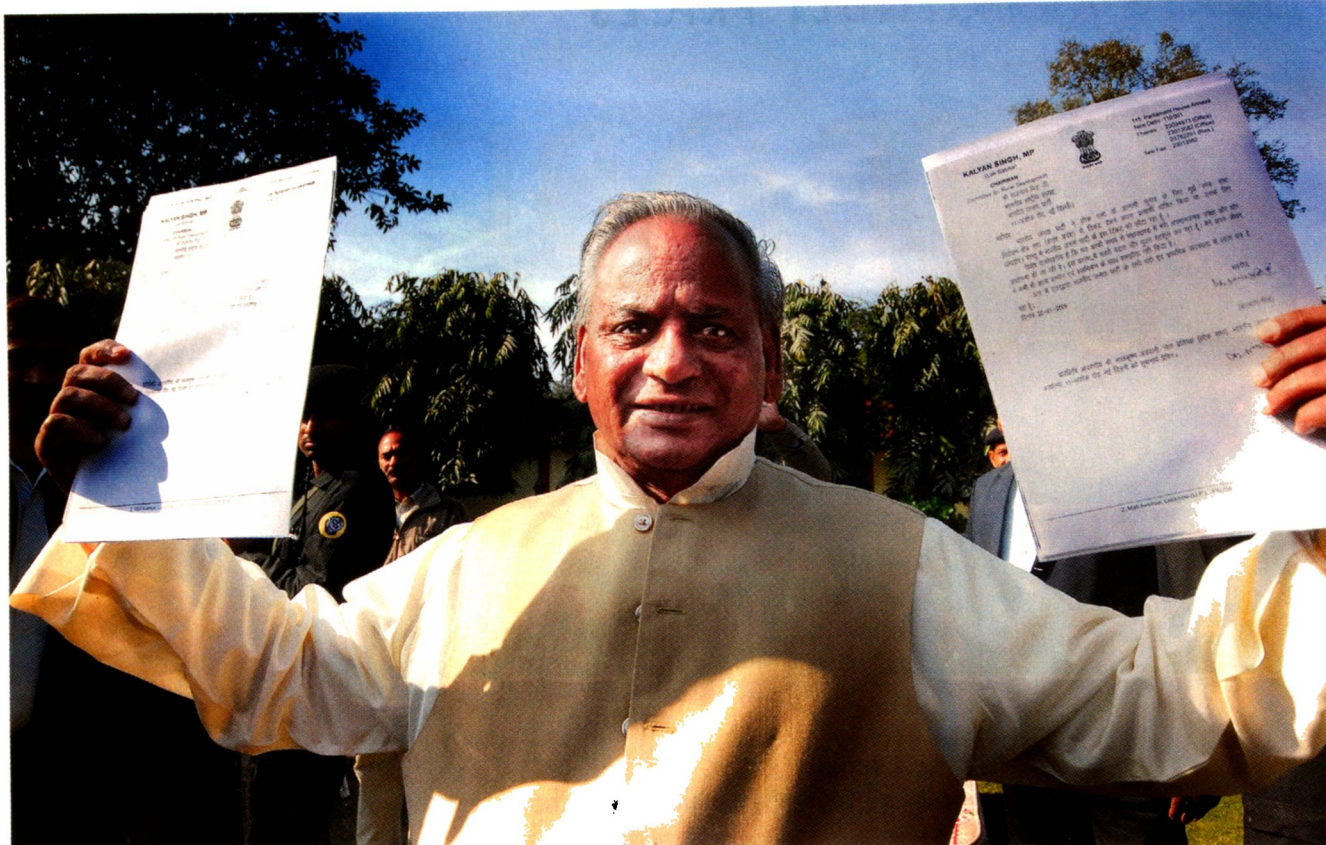




LUCKNOW | Looking Back in Anger

The departure of veteran leader Kalyan Singh from the BJP has struck yet another blow to the party that is struggling hard to survive in the crucial state of Uttar Pradesh. The state has 80 parliamentary constituencies, usually playing a central role in determining who India's prime minister will be.

Singh's resignation has only added to the BJP's slide in the state where, after the reverses in the Assembly elections in 2002 and 2007 and the 2004 parliamentary polls, it is now looking terminal. It's with survival in mind that L.K. Advani okayed a Rajya Sabha ticket to Singh's close friend Kusum Rai despite disquiet in the ranks. Singh though wanted more: the axing of Ashok Pradhan as the party's Bulandshahar candidate because he had engineered his son Rajvir's defeat in the 2007 polls. It was a demand ignored by the BJP and it stung Singh to the quick, compelling him to make an exit from the party in a huff. The man who was cajoled back to the fold in 2004 is sure he will never return. Singh now says his return then was, "a political blunder. This time I will never come back to the BJP." Like Singh, another OBC leader, Om Prakash Singh, leader of the Legislature Party of the BJP, too remains neglected by the upper caste troika of Lalji Tandon, Kalraj Mishra and Ramapati Ram Tripathi. Uttar Pradesh was once the fountainhead of the BJP, but now the lotus seems to be withering in the state. *by Subhash Mishra*

**KALYAN SINGH
AFTER FAXING
HIS RESIGNA-
TION TO THE BJP
LEADERSHIP**

88

of 403 seats
were won by
the BJP in
Uttar
Pradesh in
the 2002
Assembly
elections.